cadets from each squadron were allotted an instructor who would be responsible for their flying training. The schedule for the next five months until we would clear the solo flying test was also conveyed to us. Then onwards, two squadrons would undergo morning flying and the other two afternoon flying, on alternate weeks. Though both the sessions were equally hard, I particularly disliked the morning sessions. Every flying session started with a central briefing, known as a ‘mass briefing’, which would be scheduled at five in the morning. Flight cadets were supposed to be seated in the briefing room by half past four. This meant waking up at half past three in the morning, and for someone like me, who loved to sleep, I despised morning sessions more than anything else. Every mass briefing started with a time check to ensure everyone’s time was synchronized. It would be followed by a briefing by the meteorological officer, who would tell us about the weather conditions during the upcoming flying hours. An air traffic control officer would then brief us on NOTAMS (a special notification issued to pilots before a flight, advising them on the circumstances related to the state of flying), outstation traffic at the base and other available facilities for the day. This would be followed by the technical officer’s briefing and, lastly, a ‘pilot order’, which would be read by one of the trainee cadets. After the mass briefing, we would be sent to our respective squadrons to change from our usual light-blue shirt and blue-grey trousers to flying overalls, flying shoes and gloves. During the initial week of flying training, I had to manage with an oversized overall, since there was no size available that could fit me as I was the shortest among the cadets. Anuradha would make fun of me in the oversized overalls. I took the teasing sportingly. Together, we would go to the cafeteria of our squadron to grab a quick bite of a sandwich and sometimes a bowl of porridge. Eating a light breakfast before flights was mandatory. Each cadet would then go to their respective squadron’s ops room, where a white board with instructions would be kept for them to read through. Details regarding which cadet would undergo which sortie* and at what time would generally be inscribed on the board. I remember a quote that our instructor would always write on the white board: ‘You need to be 200 per cent prepared on